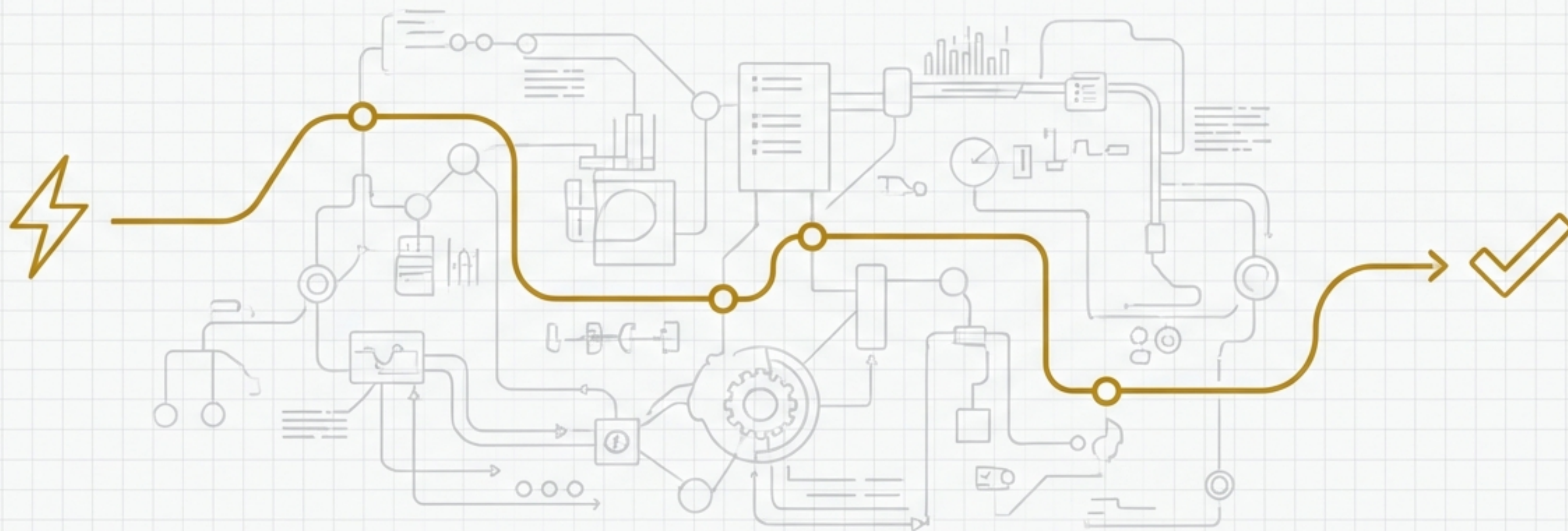


AUTOMATE TO ACCELERATE: YOUR FIRST POWER AUTOMATE MISSION

A Field Guide to Building Your First Automated Workflow



MISSION OBJECTIVE: ENHANCE OPERATIONAL READINESS

The goal of this briefing is to equip you with the skills to use automation as a force multiplier. Upon completion, you will be able to:



UNDERSTAND: The core principles of workflow automation and its strategic advantages within the Microsoft 365 ecosystem.



EXECUTE: Build a functional, automated cloud flow from scratch to handle a common communication task.



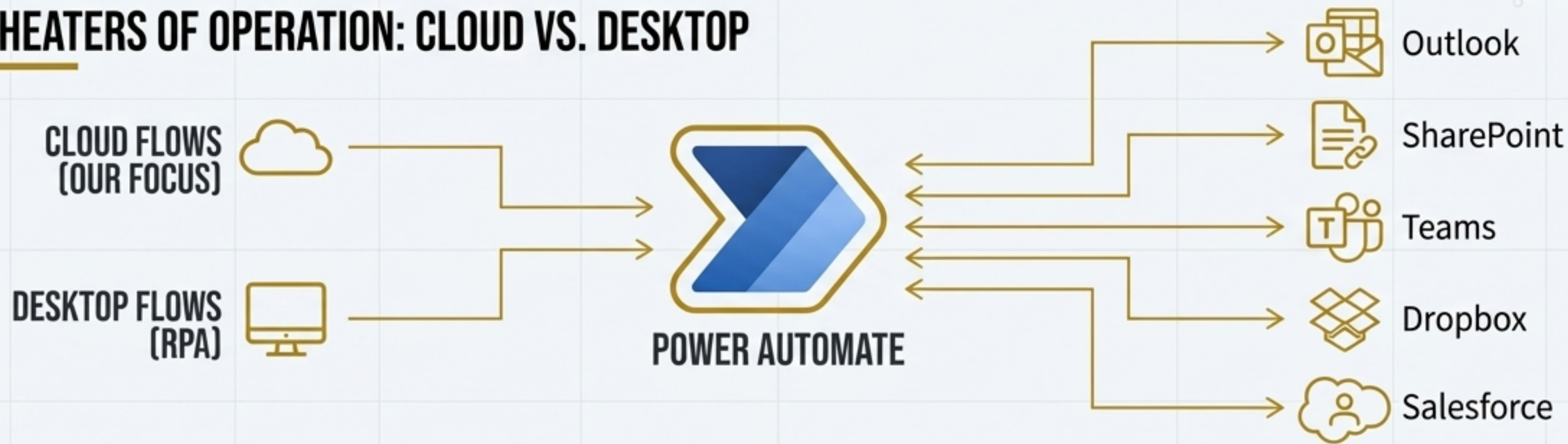
EMPOWER: Gain the foundational skills to identify and automate repetitive tasks, saving time, reducing human error, and freeing up resources for mission-critical objectives.



SITUATIONAL AWARENESS: THE DIGITAL BACKBONE OF AUTOMATION

Power Automate is Microsoft's service for creating automated workflows (called "flows") that connect different apps and services, allowing them to communicate seamlessly.

TWO THEATERS OF OPERATION: CLOUD VS. DESKTOP



ADVANTAGES OF CLOUD FLOW ARCHITECTURE:



BROWSER-BASED

Accessible from any connected device; no special software installation required.



CENTRALLY MANAGED

Monitored and governed within the Microsoft 365 ecosystem.



OPERATIONALLY RESILIENT

Runs in the cloud, independent of a local machine's status. It does not require your computer to be on or unlocked to function correctly.

CORE COMPONENTS: YOUR AUTOMATION TOOLKIT

Every cloud flow, regardless of complexity, is built from three foundational elements.



CONNECTORS

The secure gateway to your apps and services. A connector is a proxy API that allows Power Automate to interface with an external system like Office 365 Outlook or SharePoint, handling all the complex authentication and communication behind the scenes.



TRIGGERS

The specific event that starts your flow. A trigger is always the first step and defines what initiates the automation (e.g., "When a new email arrives," "When a file is created").



ACTIONS

The tasks the flow performs after it's triggered. Every step after the trigger is an action, which leverages a connector to perform a task (e.g., "Send an email," "Update a row," "Post a message").

TYPES OF CLOUD FLOWS: HOW WILL YOUR MISSION INITIATE?

The type of trigger you choose determines the type of cloud flow you create.

FLOW TYPE	INITIATION MECHANISM (TRIGGER)	TYPICAL USE CASE
Automated Flow	Triggered by an external system event.	Sending a Teams notification when a priority email arrives, or alerting users when a new file is uploaded to SharePoint.
Instant Flow	Triggered manually by a user pushing a button in an app or on a mobile device.	Sending a quick reminder to a distribution list or initiating an on-demand approval process from your phone.
Scheduled Flow	Triggered based on a predetermined recurrence schedule (e.g., daily, weekly).	Generating and sending a report every Friday at 0800, or a daily data extraction task.

THE COMMAND CENTER: THE POWER AUTOMATE DESIGNER

The screenshot shows the Microsoft Power Automate web interface. At the top is a dark header with the 'Power Automate' logo, a search bar, and user information. Below the header is a light gray toolbar with buttons for 'Save', 'Flow checker', 'Test', 'Undo', 'Redo', and 'Settings'. The main workspace is divided into three sections: a left sidebar (Configuration Pane), a central Canvas, and a right sidebar (Configuration Pane for the selected step). The Canvas shows a flow titled 'Pnenly trigger a flow' with two steps: 'Manually trigger a flow' and 'Send an email (V2)'. The right sidebar is open for the 'Send an email (V2)' step, showing fields for 'To', 'Subject', and 'Body'. Numbered callouts point to specific features: 1 points to the Canvas, 2 points to the 'Test' button, 3 points to the 'Flow checker' button, and 4 points to the 'Send an email (V2)' step in the Canvas.

1. The Canvas: The central area where you visually build the flow's logic by adding triggers and actions.

2. The Configuration Pane: The side panel where you customize the parameters, settings, and business logic for the selected step on the canvas.

3. Flow Checker: An indispensable tool (top right) that performs static analysis on your flow, identifying potential errors or warnings before you run it.

4. Test Button: The primary interface for initiating a manual or automated test to validate your flow's functionality after saving.

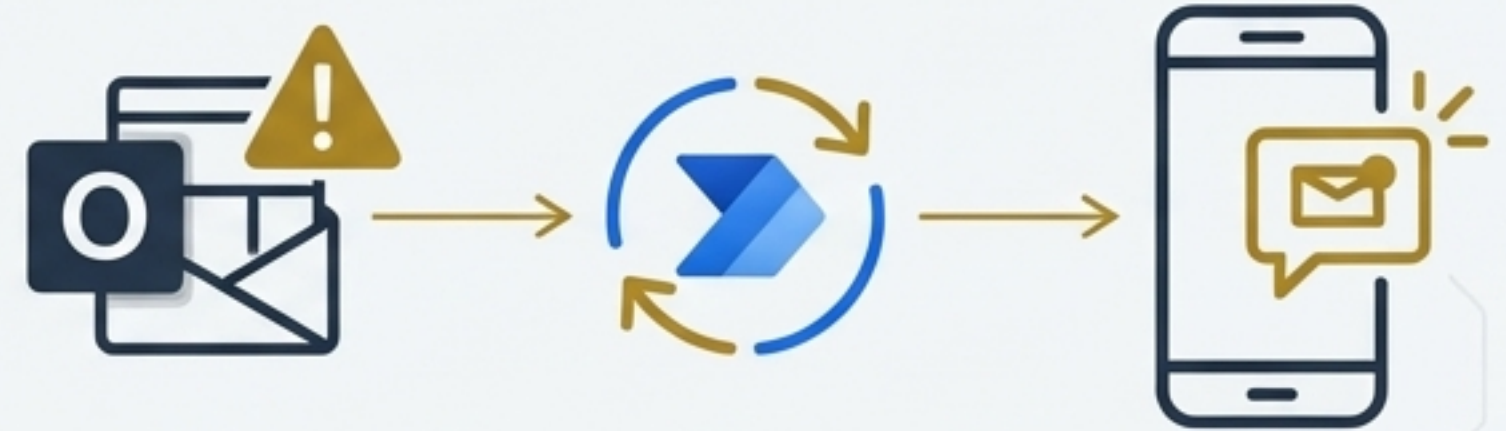
YOUR FIRST MISSION: BUILD A HIGH-PRIORITY COMMS ALERT

SCENARIO BRIEFING

Your objective is to create an Automated Cloud Flow that monitors your inbox. When a high-priority email arrives from a specific sender, the flow will instantly send a push notification to your mobile device.

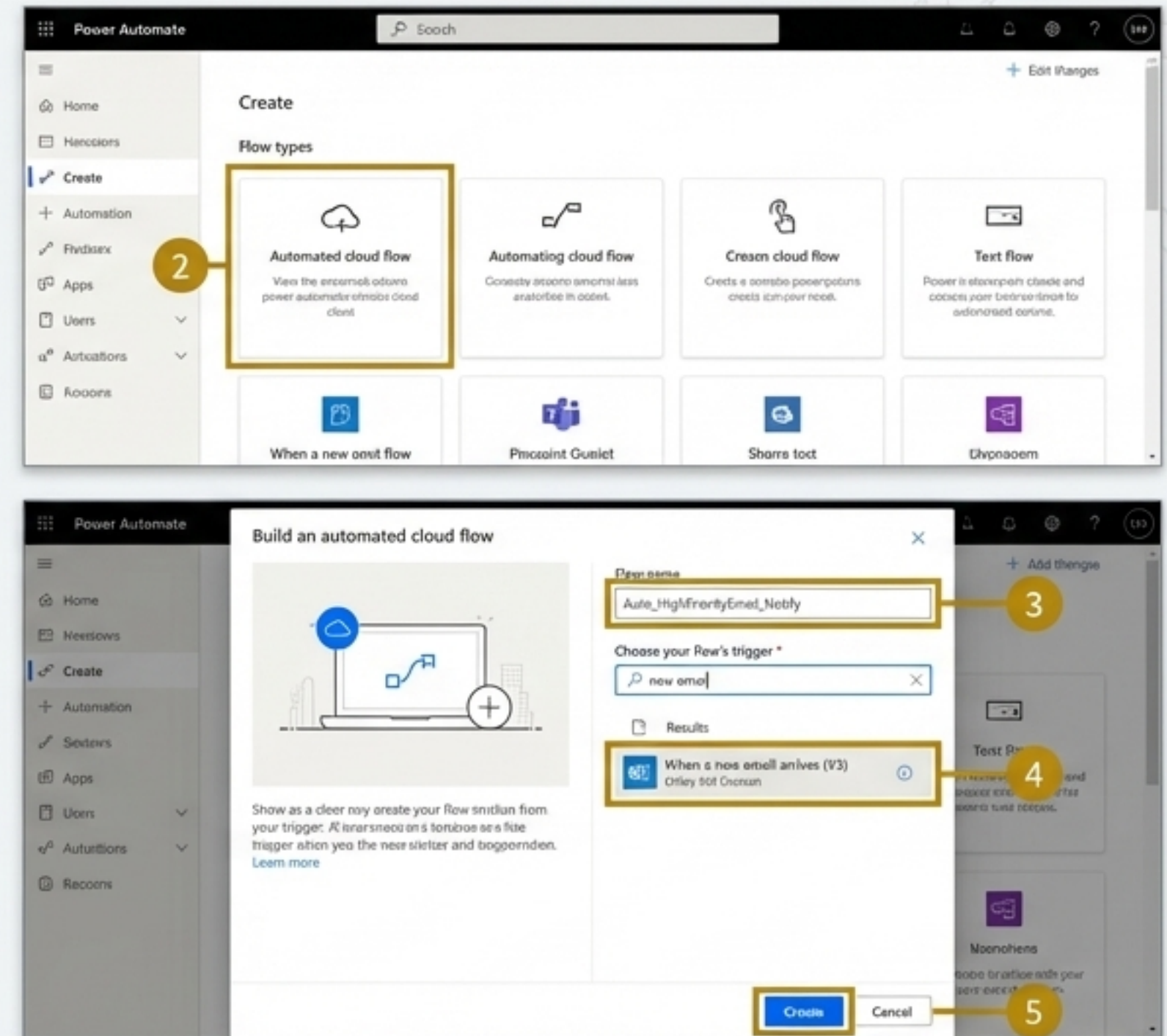
MISSION PREREQUISITES

- The Power Automate mobile app must be installed on your device.
- You must have enabled notifications for the Power Automate app in your device's system settings.



EXECUTION STEP 1: INITIATE THE FLOW

1. From the Power Automate home page, select **Create** on the left navigation pane.
2. Select **Automated cloud flow**.
3. Give your flow a descriptive name, such as Auto_HighPriorityEmail_Notify.
4. In the trigger search box ("Choose your flow's trigger"), type "new email" and select the trigger named **When a new email arrives (V3)** from the Office 365 Outlook connector.
5. Click **Create**.



EXECUTION STEP 2: APPLY TRIGGER CONDITIONS FOR EFFICIENCY



An unfiltered trigger runs on *every single email*, consuming your run quota and system resources unnecessarily. Applying filters at the trigger level ensures the flow only executes when its precise conditions are met, enhancing operational efficiency.

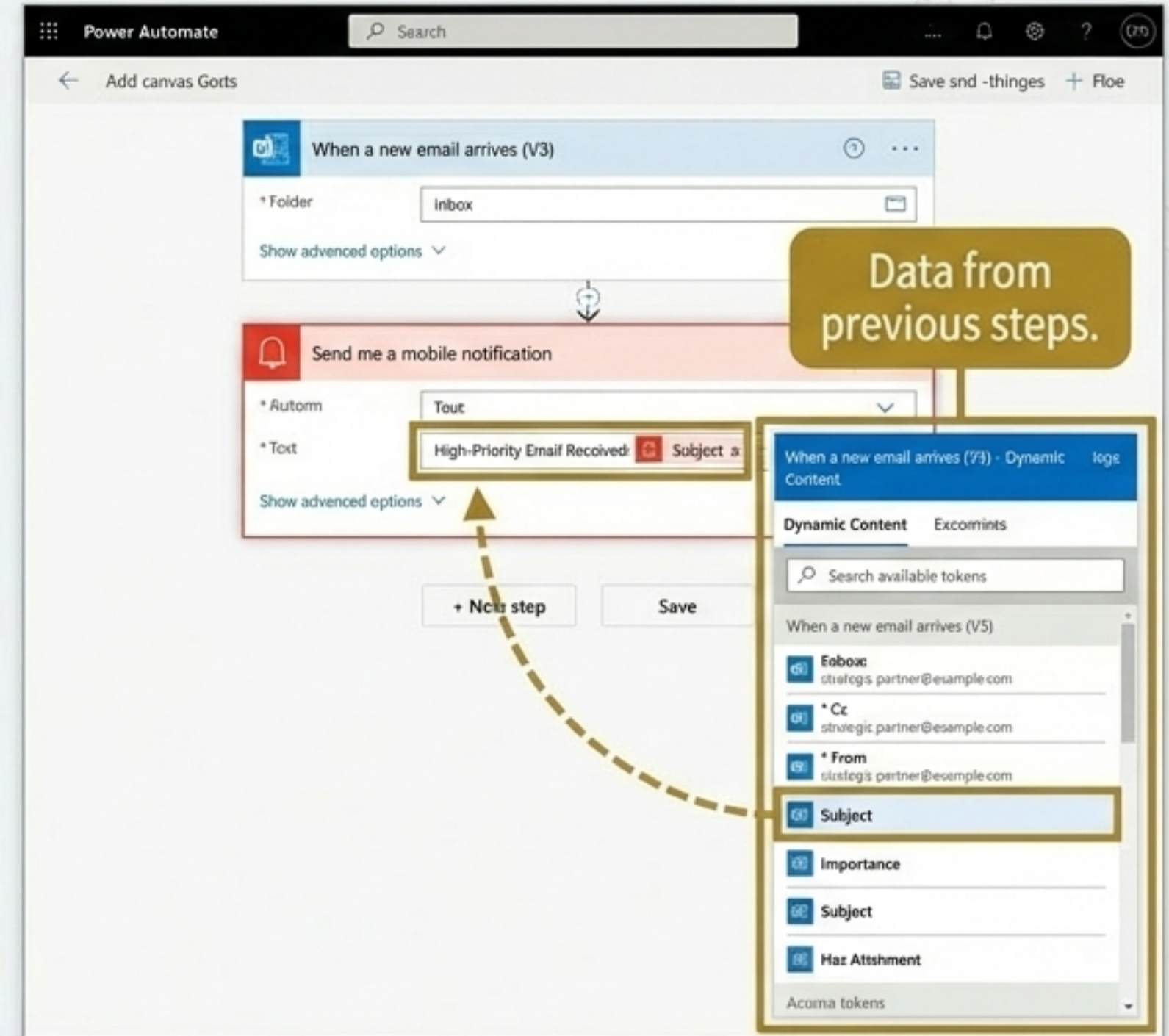
1. On the 'When a new email arrives (V3)' card, select the **Inbox** folder.
2. Click **Show advanced options** to reveal more filtering criteria.
3. In the **From** field, enter the specific sender's email address you wish to monitor.
4. In the **Importance** dropdown, select **High**.

The screenshot displays the 'When a new email arrives (V3)' trigger configuration in Power Automate. The interface includes the following elements:

- Folder:** A dropdown menu set to 'Inbox' (indicated by callout 1).
- Show advanced options:** A link to expand the configuration (indicated by callout 2).
- To:** A text field containing 'strategic.partner@example.com'.
- Cc:** A text field containing 'strategic.partner@example.com'.
- From:** A text field containing 'strategic.partner@example.com' (indicated by callout 3).
- Importance:** A dropdown menu set to 'High' (indicated by callout 4).
- Has Attachment:** Three dropdown menus, all set to 'No'.
- Show advanced options:** A link at the bottom to collapse the configuration.

EXECUTION STEP 3: DEFINE THE ACTION & USE DYNAMIC CONTENT

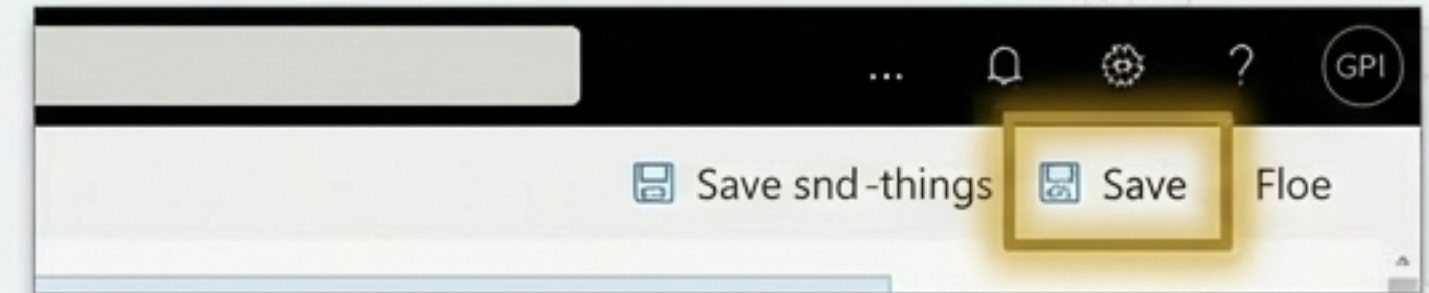
1. Click **+ New step** below the trigger.
2. In the search box, type 'notification' and select the action **Send me a mobile notification**.
3. In the **Text** field of the action card, type a static message like:
High-Priority Email Received: `
4. With your cursor still in the **Text** field, the **Dynamic Content** panel will appear. This panel contains all data outputs from previous steps.
5. Select **Subject** from the Dynamic Content list. This will add a token representing the subject line of the triggering email to your notification text.



EXECUTION STEP 4: FINAL VALIDATION AND ACTIVATION

1. SAVE

Click the **Save** button in the top-right corner of the designer.



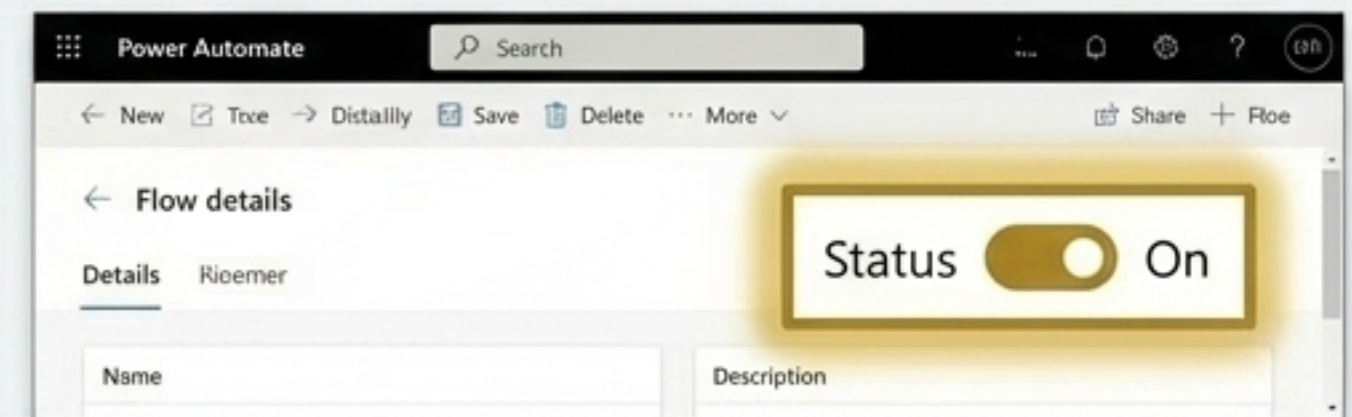
2. TEST

After saving, click the **Test** button. Select the **Manually** option and then click **Test**. You will be prompted to send a test email that matches your trigger conditions (from the specified sender with high importance).



3. ACTIVATE

After a successful test, navigate to the flow's details page (by clicking the back arrow). Ensure the status toggle is set to **On**. Your flow is now live and monitoring your inbox.



POST-MISSION ANALYSIS: DIAGNOSING WITH RUN HISTORY

The Run History is your primary tool for debugging and analysis. It provides a detailed, step-by-step log of every time your flow has executed.

The image shows two screenshots from a software interface. The left screenshot displays a '28-day run history' table with columns for Start time, Status, Duration, and Inputs/Outputs. A specific run is highlighted with a yellow box. A large yellow arrow points from this highlighted row to the right screenshot, which shows a detailed 'Flow trace' for that specific run. The flow trace shows a sequence of steps: 'When a new email arrives (V3)' and 'Send me a mobile notification'. Each step has a status icon (green checkmark for success, red X for failure). The 'Send me a mobile notification' step is expanded, showing its 'Inputs' and 'Outputs' data. Annotations with yellow lines point to the status icons and the data fields, explaining their function.

Start time	Status	Duration	Inputs/Outputs
Oct 26, 2023, 10:30 AM	✓ Succeeded	01:05	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:40 AM	✓ Succeeded	01:04	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:30 AM	✓ Succeeded	01:05	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:37 AM	✓ Succeeded	01:06	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:33 AM	✗ Failed	01:03	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:28 AM	✗ Failed	01:02	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:31 AM	✗ Failed	01:02	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:31 PM	✗ Failed	01:07	View details
Oct 26, 2023, 10:10 PM	✗ Failed	01:06	View details

Each step shows its status.

Inspect the exact data that was processed.

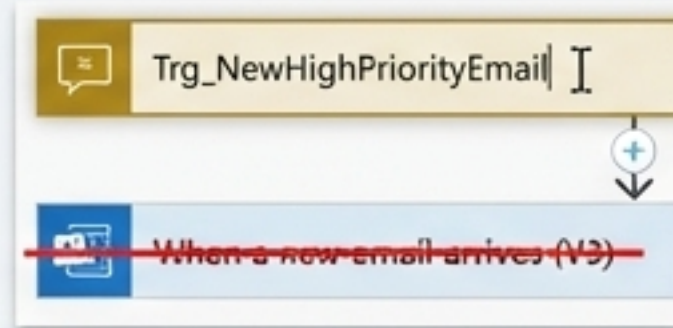
From the flow details page, click on a specific run to see a detailed trace. Within the trace, you can click on each step to inspect its exact **Inputs and Outputs**. This allows you to see the precise data that was processed, which is critical for identifying where a failure occurred.

RULES OF ENGAGEMENT: BUILDING FOR DURABILITY & CLARITY

Following these standards ensures your automations are maintainable, easy to troubleshoot, and scalable.

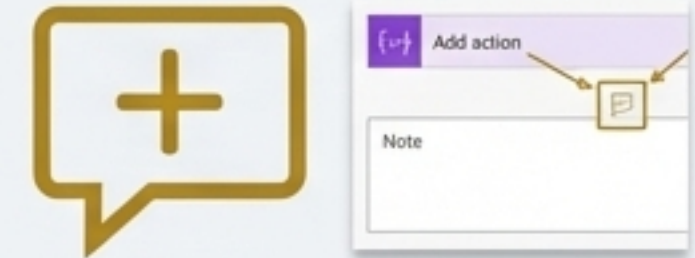
1. Use Clear Naming Conventions

Rename your steps and triggers.
Change generic names like "When a new email arrives (V3)" to `Trg\_NewHighPriorityEmail`.
Use prefixes like `Trg\_` for Triggers and `Act\_` for Actions. This is critical for readability and maintenance.



2. Add Intelligence (Notes)

For complex actions or logic, use the "Add a note" feature to explain the *why* behind your configuration. This creates a clear audit trail for yourself and others.



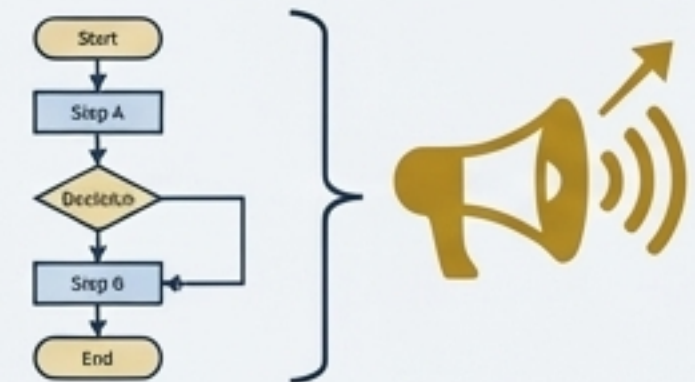
3. Avoid Hardcoding

Never put specific email addresses, SharePoint site URLs, or list names directly in actions. Store these values in variables or retrieve them from a configuration source. This makes flows portable and easy to update.



4. Automation Amplifies Process

An app or a flow cannot fix a broken business process. You must have a structured, repeatable process defined *first*. Then, build the automation to amplify its efficiency. You cannot build the airplane while it is in flight.



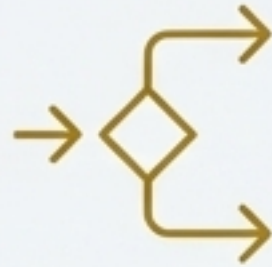
YOUR NEXT MISSION: EXPANDING YOUR AUTOMATION SKILLS

With your first flow complete, you are ready to tackle more complex scenarios. Focus on these areas to expand your capabilities:



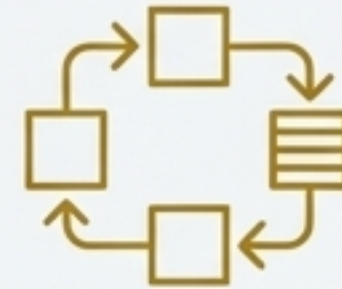
Explore Templates

Power Automate offers a vast library of pre-built templates for common business scenarios. Use them to accelerate development and learn how complex flows are structured.



Incorporate Logic with Conditions

Learn to use the **Condition** action. This allows your flow to perform different actions based on the data it receives (e.g., 'If the subject contains 'Urgent', do X, otherwise do Y').



Handle Groups of Items

Investigate the **Apply to each** loop. This control structure is essential for processing multiple items at once, such as saving multiple email attachments or updating multiple rows in a list.

MISSION COMPLETE



You are now equipped to automate.

Identify repetitive, manual tasks in your daily workflow. Automate them.
Reclaim your time for mission-critical objectives.

****Resources & Points of Contact****

Internal Community of Practice: [Link to SharePoint or Teams Channel]

IT Support Desk: [Contact Information / Ticketing System Link]

Power Platform SME: [Name and Contact of internal lead]